

FROM STENCH TO STRENGTH



Care Today helps revive a deteriorating stretch of land in quake-hit Bhuj by developing a green belt and installing a sewage treatment plant



GREEN WITH PRIDE:
Waste water treatment
plant at Bhuj

On January 26, 2001, a massive earthquake measuring 7.9 on the Richter scale hit Gujarat. It wreaked havoc, killing more than 30,000, injuring 5,000 and leaving about half a million homeless, besides crippling its basic infrastructure.

Six years later, the city of Bhuj (the epicentre of the quake), which bore the brunt of the catastrophe, is back on its feet, donning a brand new look much different from its pre-earthquake days. It not only boasts of state-of-the-art infrastructure and high quality basic services, but has boldly implemented new tools of planning and the latest technology to respond to ubiquitous urban problems. One such problem was the deteriorating condition of the area around the rivulets flowing through Bhuj into the Hamirsar Lake. The 12-km stretch had become a dumping ground for garbage and was often used for defecation. The rivulets themselves were disasters waiting to happen with waste material impeding the flow of water to the lake.

In a community effort, the Hunnarshala Foundation (a local NGO with expertise in architecture and urban planning) identified a 500-m stretch around the rivulets and with the involvement of residents, NGOs and the municipal corporation converted it into a green belt.

Apart from this, a decentralised waste water treatment system (DEWATS) was installed to treat 30,000 liters of sewage every day. The recycled water was then used to irrigate trees and plants along the banks of the rivulets. The banks were landscaped to make way for

seating benches and walkways. The project got full support from NGOs and residents who resorted to 'Gandhigiri' to create awareness for the initiative and implemented a cleanliness drive to stop dumping of garbage and defecation in and around the area.

Today, this stretch has become Bhuj's pride. According to P.C. Jadeja, a contractor and former corporator, "The green stretch has given a common space to the residents to enjoy themselves in nature's lap." Some of the adjoining buildings that had erected walls to keep away the stench from the *nallah* are now contemplating breaking them.

According to Sandeep Virmani of the Hunnarshala Foundation, the beauty of the DEWATS system is its simplicity—the treatment of sewage is based on gravitational flow, it requires zero maintenance and the plant doesn't need any specialist to look after its functioning. The project demonstrates solutions to some of the problems faced in urban India, of disappearing water channels, shrinking public spaces and water logging during the monsoons.

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